

WhatsApp India

Optional consent and privacy controls under DPDP Act

Goal: make optional data use easier to understand and easier to refuse, without adding friction to core messaging.

Why this matters: WhatsApp's trust moat depends on keeping the service simple while making optional data use more legible.

What this deck covers

Product: WhatsApp India

Focus: optional consent, backup, business/discovery use, privacy control center

Assumption: message content stays end-to-end encrypted and out of scope

Why WhatsApp is tricky here

WhatsApp feels easy because most privacy decisions sit quietly in the background. That gets harder to maintain once the product expands into backup, business messaging, discovery, and new identity layers.

DPDP Act pushes WhatsApp to separate what is necessary to run the service from what should be a clearer, revocable choice.

Scope and assumptions

WhatsApp India. Focus on optional consent and data-rights control. Message content remains end-to-end encrypted and out of scope.

What users expect

Private, low-effort communication with people they already know

What the company wants

Identity, safety, backup, business messaging, and growth surfaces

What DPDP changes

Purpose has to be clearer and user control has to be easier to exercise later

The hard part is not the law itself. It is deciding which data users deserve a real user choice.

What users actually worry about

Anxieties that show up in real use

Who can find me?

Will I lose my chats if I switch phones?

What changes when I message a business?

What exactly happens if I say yes here?

What this means for the solution

The solution should not be built around age bands or abstract privacy awareness.

It should be built around four situations: discovery, continuity, business interaction, and routine messaging.

That gives a clearer basis for consent timing and controls.

The issue is not a lack of settings. It is a lack of separation between data uses.

WHAT USERS OFTEN SEE

Today, the user experience is fragmented across account setup, phone permissions, backup, business flows, and settings.

Signup

**Permission
asks**

**Buried
settings**

**Reactive
rights flow**

Too much too early

Requests show up before the user has enough context to understand the trade-off.

Too little clarity later

Optional uses become background assumptions instead of explicit, revisitable choices.

Weak ongoing state

The user cannot easily see what is active now or what would change if they said no.

What this creates

Consent quality becomes weak.

Withdrawal and rights actions are harder to find.

Trust depends on policy reading instead of product clarity.

Not every WhatsApp data use needs the same consent treatment

Essential service processing

Account setup, delivery, fraud and spam prevention

This is needed to run WhatsApp. The product should explain it clearly, but it should not pretend this is an optional opt-in.

Useful but optional features

Contact sync, backup, recovery

Ask only when the feature becomes relevant. Explain what the user gets, what data is used, and what happens if they skip it.

Non-essential business uses

Business discovery and other company-benefit uses

These need the clearest consent. Saying no should not break core messaging.

Rights and ongoing control

Access, export, correction, deletion, withdrawal

Users need one persistent place to see active choices and take action later.

What the product would actually do

The product should move from one-time blanket consent to a simpler three-part system.

1. Signup notice

At signup, show one short notice explaining what WhatsApp must process to create the account, deliver messages, and prevent abuse.

This sets expectations early without turning signup into a wall of permissions.

2. In-context prompts

Ask for optional data only when the user is about to use the feature that needs it.

The prompt should say what data is used, why now, and what changes if the user declines.

3. Privacy hub

Create one place where the user can see active permissions, withdraw optional consent, and request export or deletion.

This makes ongoing control visible instead of burying it across settings.

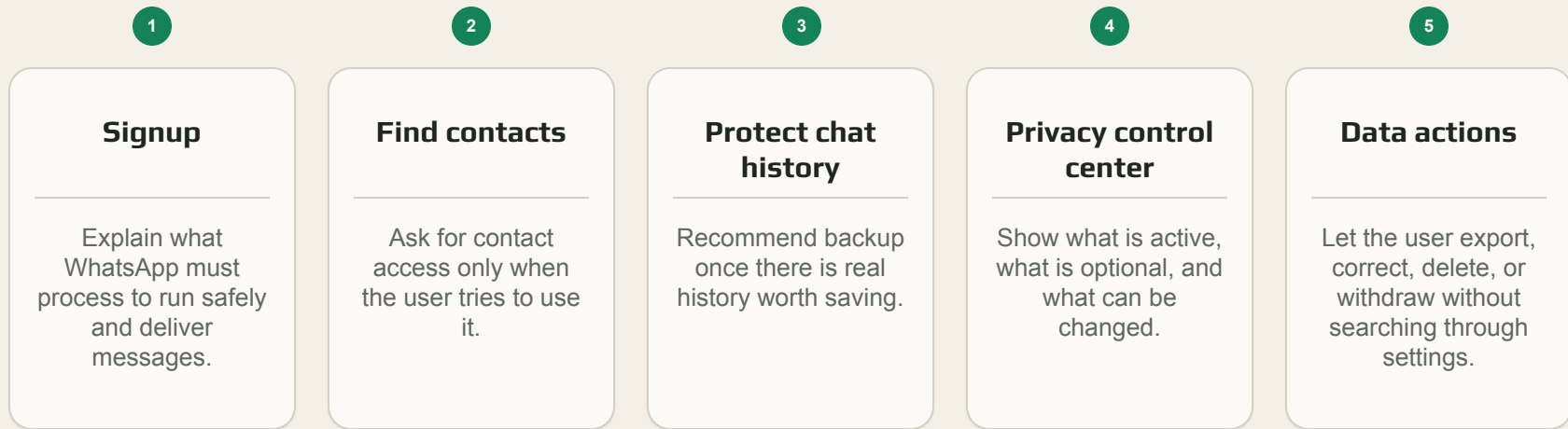
Example: contact sync

Prompt this only when the user taps Find Contacts. The reason is obvious in that moment, so the ask feels tied to value instead of surveillance.

Example: backup

Prompt this after the user has enough chat history to care about losing it. Backup is optional, but the product should raise it before regret sets in.

The timing of the ask matters as much as the ask itself



Design rule: ask only when the reason for the request is obvious, then make the choice easy to revisit later.

If users don't understand the choice, a high opt-in rate is misleading

North Star

78%

MAUs with valid current optional consent state

Trend over time

Share of MAUs with valid optional-consent state (%)



Segmentation

Existing users		83
iOS		81
Android		76
New users		70

Success criteria

+20% point comprehension lift
90% rights requests within SLA
No more than 2% signup drop

Consent by purpose
Withdrawal by purpose
Backup enablement after explanation

Guardrails: signup completion, day-7 messaging activity, contact-find success, and privacy-related support tickets

If the North Star drops 15% after launch, I would first ask where the drop is coming from

Hypothesis tree

1. Measurement failure

Tracking, classification, or data delay issues

2. Experience failure

Confusing copy, bad timing, or unclear recovery after decline

3. Cohort or platform failure

Android versus iOS, new versus existing users, language, geography, app version

4. Strategy failure

Too much friction in a high-frequency flow or a request that feels company-serving

What I would inspect first

- 1 Break the drop by purpose. Is it contact sync, backup, business use, or all of them?
- 2 Break it by platform, language, geography, app version, and user age cohort if relevant.
- 3 Compare prompt impressions, accept rate, decline rate, withdrawal, and later reversal by entry point.
- 4 Check whether users who declined could still finish the job they came to do.
- 5 Validate instrumentation before changing product behavior.

Some extra friction is acceptable if it protects trust in messaging

Rollout

- 1 Dogfood internally with employee and test cohorts
- 2 Launch to a small India cohort with heavy instrumentation
- 3 A/B test the wording and timing of prompts, but do not A/B test whether users get core disclosures or rights.
- 4 Expand by use case, then platform, then broader audience

Risks and edge cases

- Some optional consent rates may fall once the asks become clearer.
- Decline paths must preserve core messaging and make consequences clear.
- Deletion and export requests need visible status, not just a confirmation screen.
- Under-18 users should be routed to a separate parental-consent model.

The goal is not to add more privacy screens. It is to make optional data use easier to understand, easier to refuse, and less likely to damage trust in messaging.